

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

The Tea Bag Test



The tri-nation ODI series in Australia is usually a tiresome formality undergone by touring teams drained by the Tests that precede it. Teams hare around Australia playing each other four times before the final, by which time no one is interested in the result anymore. But trust India to give the tri-series an edge.

To start with, the squad. Picked with tomorrow in mind it is meant to give India's Gen Next 100-odd ODIs by the time the 2011 World Cup comes home. Considering that this call was made by the same selectors who picked Virender Sehwag and Ishant Sharma for the Tests, it's not a smart idea to reach for the revolver shouting "jokers" and "clueless" in the same sentence.

Then, this team for tomorrow bats like they cannot decide whether they are a feast for the gods or a collapsing soufflé. Some decisions taken have been real mind-benders: like why didn't M.S. Dhoni promote himself up the order in the very first match instead of sending out shotmakers, prodigies and the jet-lagged one after the other? Of all the batsmen in the Indian ODI team bar Sachin Tendulkar, Dhoni has had the maximum time at the crease in Australia.

India needed stickability against Australia on a damp Gabba wicket and on this tour he had, in fact, modelled himself as dogged stayer rather than explosive floater. Dhoni called it 'instinctive' but sending in the rookies was, at best, optimistic. Hopefully, all the residual T20 hangover and jet-lag has now vanished.

This tri-series is probably the best tea-bag test for all tyros who aspire to nail down ODI slots: we will find out how strong they are when they get put into hot water. In cricket, nothing is hotter than Australia.

The success of the young is rightly celebrated because their arrival marks renewal. India must now be alert to not airbrushing end-result failures with big-picture buzz words like 'processes' or lazy catch-phrases like 'gotta lose some to win some'. Repeated lapses in first-skill areas (in this case, batting) must not be glossed over because of the team's strong second-skill—fielding.

Dhoni and the bats need to show India enough signs of why it was a good idea to ask Sourav Ganguly, Rahul Dravid and V.V.S. Laxman to go home—and not only by taking catching blinders or running fast. But by providing good starts, playing fluently in crises and anchoring chases. By being competitive and getting results. What India needs to see from this ODI team is growth: processes are a good coaching tool but visible progress is better.



SAURABH SINGH

RAV S SAMAN



The Baba and the Bomb

CHANDIGARH An audacious bomb attack on the controversial Dera Sacha Sauda chief Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh by former Punjab terrorists has sent alarm bells ringing for security agencies in Punjab and Haryana. Singh, whose act of imitating Guru Gobind Singh had led to widespread Sikh protests last year, narrowly escaped a bid on his life on February 2 when his motorcade was targeted with an RDX-laden bomb tied to a truck on the Grand Trunk Road near Karnal.

The Sirsa-based sect chief's frequent trips to Ambala for court appearances in three criminal cases of murder and rape apparently made him vulnerable to a plot hatched by former Khalistan Commando Force militant Bakshish Singh who is on bail in a number of terrorist cases pending against him. While Bakshish is absconding, two of his

accomplices who triggered the blast were arrested and have spilled the beans on the attack.

The Karnal incident comes close on the heels of the busting of a Babbar Khalsa module in Punjab two months ago, which had shed light on the dormant but dreaded militant outfit's plans to kill the Sacha Sauda head. "Certain ISI-supported groups are trying to exploit the religious sentiments to revive their remnants in Punjab," says DGP N.P.S. Aulakh, ruling out the possibility of revival of terrorism in the state.

Alarmed by a barrage of intelligence reports on insidious terror plots, the Haryana Government has written to the court to shift Baba's trial to Sirsa, while the Punjab Police has bolstered the security of Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal and his son, Shiromani Akali Dal President Sukhbir Singh.

by Ramesh Vinayak